



A DRIVE-THROUGH worker manages long lines at the In-N-Out Burger outlet on Venice Boulevard in L.A.

U.S. is unlikely to act as Ortega bars vote

In Nicaragua, some hope for a Maduro-style ouster. But chances appear slim.

By KATE LINTHICUM AND ISMAEL LÓPEZ

MEXICO CITY — President Daniel Ortega of Nicaragua is the longest-serving leader in the Americas, having abolished term limits shortly after taking office nearly two decades ago. The former guerrilla fighter has violently crushed protests and closed churches, universities, nonprofits and newsrooms. Ahead of the most recent presidential vote, in 2021, he eliminated the competition by throwing his most credible challengers in jail. So when Ortega, 80, marked the 47th anniversary of his leftist movement's revolution last week by declaring that "there will never be elections here again," few Nicaraguans were surprised. If anything, some hoped that Ortega's brazen decree might draw renewed attention to a country that many feel has been forgotten even as it sinks deeper into authoritarianism. Nicaraguans "live in a state of terror," said Dora María Téllez, a prominent Ortega critic who was im-

[See Nicaragua, A4]

Drive-through eateries are hitting roadblocks

By SUHAUNA HUSSAIN

Many cities — not to mention their hungry residents — are eager for burger icon In-N-Out to open an outpost. The chain has been expanding rapidly, finding there are plenty of customers for each new location. But there is one Southern California city that is pushing back. When In-N-Out recently approached Culver City with interest in opening one of its drive-through restaurants in the West-side community, it sparked a backlash. Some residents expressed concerns about pollution, the traffic congestion, the dangers of errant drivers around kids and the lingering aroma of frying food. The City Council listened, imposing a moratorium on new drive-throughs. The battle in Culver City has gained national attention because it highlights

larger concerns about the proliferation of drive-through restaurants. The car-friendly layout has been booming for decades, with many seeing the car lanes as essential to making the restaurants work financially. The pandemic boosted the concept even more, offering a low-risk, low-contact way to get food. California's first drive-through was an In-N-Out in Baldwin Park in 1948, and by the 1960s, the new approach to dining had begun to reshape the American landscape. But Culver City is part of a small but notable rebellion. At a recent City Council meeting, residents took the mic one by one to speak passionately on an issue that has grown

[See Drive-through, A9]

Battling AI, hiring to use it

Job postings reveal Hollywood studios are quietly adapting even as many in the industry are resisting

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

As performers protest and studios sue in their war on artificial intelligence, the entertainment industry is deepening its dependence on it. Although few places are better than Hollywood at crafting a narrative and concealing what happens off-frame, a Los Angeles Times survey of job postings sheds light on what is happening offstage. Among hundreds of job postings in late June, more than 1 in 10 was likely connected to AI. The top studios' public postings suggest they have been recruiting

people to build AI tools. They are also recruiting teams to defend their intellectual property against unauthorized AI use. "There are plenty of studios that are hiring [for AI] but never talk about it in public," said Yoland Yan, a co-founder of ComfyUI, a company that helps studios juggle different AI tools. Companies have been hesitant to detail how they use generative AI in film production, partly because they are concerned about consumer and union backlash. Some in Hollywood described AI use as the new

cosmetic surgery, where everyone knows it is happening, but few will admit to it. Recent want ads show Amazon MGM Studios trying to find a principal AI executive and Walt Disney Studios advertising for a production innovation technologist job. "What you're seeing in those job postings is that adoption is already happening," said Bryn Mooser, chief executive of Asteria, an AI film studio. Netflix recently posted a job that didn't exist a year ago.

[See Jobs, A11]

L.A. homeless authority fights for its survival

A HUD investigation into alleged mismanagement at the agency could slash its core responsibilities

By Doug Smith



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

AMANDA TURNER, who is homeless, waits in line during a weekly food giveaway on Skid Row in June.

The organization that has been the front line of the Los Angeles city and county response to homelessness for more than 30 years is fighting for its survival in a U.S. court battle over a Trump administration attempt to cut its access to hundreds of millions of dollars in federal funds. The Los Angeles Homeless Services Authority is asking the court to block a federal government suspension of its role as the administrator for about \$240 million in funds from the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development. HUD has launched an inspector general investigation of alleged misconduct at the agency and suspended it from procuring federal funds while the investigation is underway. Though the scope of the suspension is not clear, LAHSA has concluded that,

in addition to ending its role as administrator of federal grants, HUD is suspending some of its principal responsibilities: conducting the annual homeless count, maintaining the homeless database and managing the system for matching homeless people to housing vacancies. Those losses would reduce LAHSA, already depleted by the withdrawal of county funding that made up more than a third of its budget, to a shell of the \$845-million agency that had ballooned over the last decade with local sales tax dollars approved by county voters. LAHSA, formed in 1993 as part of the settlement of litigation between the city and county, grew dramatically after 2016, when city voters approved a \$1.2-billion homeless housing bond, and the following year, when county voters approved a

[See LAHSA, A11]

A union chief, the billionaire tax, an alleged bargaining chip

Questions arise on how and why the controversial measure landed on the ballot.

By TARYN LUNA

SACRAMENTO — As the architect of a one-time tax on California billionaires, Dave Regan says he's pushing the measure to raise \$100 billion to protect low-income patients, workers and hospitals from President Trump's cuts to health-care. The behind-the-scenes negotiations with Gov. Gavin Newsom's office in June to pull the measure off the ballot, however, revealed another possible goal, according to two sources familiar with the talks who requested anonymity to share details of the discussions with The Times. Regan, the president of SEIU-United Healthcare Workers West, asked for union contracts with two hospitals in San Diego and Fresno and a clinic in Imperial County, among a list of sweeping demands to grow his union, in exchange for rescinding the measure, the sources said.

The union leader denied that he asked for concessions for his union in exchange for removing the billionaire tax from the ballot, calling the allegations "categorically false." "We are trying to solve a problem," Regan said. "The problem is to prevent a catastrophe in California's healthcare system. We put forward a proposal. Nobody else has offered a solution, and none of what you are referencing happened." The talks failed to result in a deal and the measure will appear as Proposition 40 on the November ballot, leaving California voters to decide pivotal tax policy that has roiled the Democratic Party and opponents worry could ultimately reduce revenue for the state budget. The terms Regan allegedly laid out raise the question of whether he intended for the billionaire tax to go on the ballot, or if it was designed as a leverage play to expand his union, which represents more than 120,000 workers and is among the largest healthcare unions in the nation. Regan, who has been elected to five consecutive

[See Regan, A10]

Trump crypto riches stall digital-asset bill

By STEVEN T. DENNIS AND SCOTT PATTERSON

President Trump's \$14-billion crypto windfall has become the biggest obstacle to passing his sweeping digital-asset legislation as Democrats demand tougher language to prevent the president from profiting off an industry his administration regulates. Senate Republicans released a proposal last week intended to break a months-long impasse over the bill, known as the Clarity Act. But Democrats and consumer watchdog groups dismissed the terms almost immediately, complaining the bill would not stop Trump or his family from continuing to profit from his meme coin and other crypto ventures. Trump needs the sup-

port of at least seven Senate Democrats to pass the legislation, which would set rules for digital assets. Ethics has emerged as the biggest, though not the only, sticking point. "It's the linchpin," said Sen. Angela Alsobrooks, a Maryland Democrat and key negotiator who has been supportive of the crypto industry. A spokesperson for the White House didn't immediately respond to a request for comment. The White House has consistently asserted Trump is not involved in managing the family's crypto ventures and has denied conflicts of interest. Democrats have specifically taken issue with a provision that would leave Trump's Justice Department

[See Crypto, A13]



WILLIAM HALE IRWIN For The Times

AMONG THE MANY

Crowds are overwhelming Yosemite National Park this summer, but there's still fun to be had if you plan ahead for your visit. WEEKEND, L6

Lineage is fined by L.A. County

Warehouse operator gets \$500 citation after fire that left pests, foul odors throughout Boyle Heights. CALIFORNIA, B1

Weather

Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 88/68. B8

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Democrats pick Senate candidate

Troy Jackson secures nomination in Maine to challenge Sen. Susan Collins. NATION, A6

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